INSIDE THE INDUSTRY

NEVER WRITE "FIXER-UPPER" IN A LISTING.

That word is quietly costing your seller money.

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Keeping It Real Podcast

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"FIXER-UPPER" TELLS EVERY BUYER TO LOWBALL YOU BEFORE THEY SEE THE KITCHEN.

Zillow studied more than two million listings. The word has a price.

03 / 05

FIXER-UPPER HOMES SOLD FOR 14% LESS THAN EXPECTED.

Zillow analyzed over 2 million listings sold in 2025 across 600-plus phrases. Homes labeled "fixer-upper" sold for 14% less than expected. "Turnkey" was tied to 2.9% more, and "remodeled" to 2.2% more. Part of that gap is the house itself. But the label also arrives before a buyer has toured a single room, and it tells them exactly how to open the negotiation.

THE SWAP, WORD FOR WORD:

1 **Don't write "fixer-upper."**
It reads as permission to lowball before a showing.

2 **Do write what it actually needs.**
"Original windows." "Dated kitchen." "Needs a new roof." Specific, not a label.

3 **Don't write "handyman special" or "as-is" as the headline.**
Same lowball signal, different words.

4 **Do let buyers price the work themselves.**
They will do the math either way. Give them the facts, not a word that does it for them at your seller's expense.

THE TAKEAWAY

CHECK EVERY ACTIVE LISTING YOU HAVE. FIND THE WORD "FIXER-UPPER." TAKE IT OUT.

Say what the house needs. Let buyers price the work, not the label.

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